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Albert P'Rayan



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"You are a slow learner. Your performance in class tests is not good. Maths and you can never be friends." Several years ago, a friend shared that this is what a teacher had said to his daughter after she had performed poorly in a class test and how deeply the remark had affected her.

Imagine that someone labelled a "slow learner" as a student later became a great scientist and won a Nobel Prize. What would we conclude?

Would we blame the teacher for wrongly judging the student? Would we blame an education system that failed to recognise the student's abilities? Or would we accept that school performance does not necessarily determine a person's future and that every individual has the potential to excel?

Damaging label

History offers examples of individuals whose early academic performance was far from impressive but who later achieved remarkable success. Albert Einstein, Mahatma Gandhi, Winston Churchill, Walt Disney, and Richard Branson are often cited in this context.

What might have happened if they had been labelled "slow learners" and discouraged by their teachers? Their potential might have been overlooked and their achievements might never have been realised.

The term "slow learner" can, therefore, be a damaging label because it may cause teachers to underestimate a student's potential. Students do not learn at the same pace or in the same way. They come from different backgrounds and have different abilities, interests, prior knowledge, strengths, and levels of readiness. Recognising these differences is essential for effective teaching and learning.

Yet many classrooms continue to rely on a one-size-fits-all approach. Instead of expecting all students to adapt to a single teaching style, should teachers not also adapt their approaches to accommodate diverse learning needs?

Where is the problem?

During the past two decades, as a teacher trainer and educator, I have often been asked how teachers should deal with "slow learners". When I ask what they mean by the term, teachers usually describe students who take longer than others to understand certain concepts or who perform poorly academically.

I then ask: Have you tried to understand why these students take longer to grasp certain concepts? Have you explained the concepts in different ways? Could another teaching approach help them understand more easily? Finally, if someone called you or your child a "slow learner," how would you feel?

These questions often encourage teachers to look beyond the label and consider whether the difficulty lies entirely with the learner. Sometimes, the real problem may be a mismatch between how something is taught and the way a student is able to understand it.

The term "slow learner" is often a misnomer because it creates the impression that some students are inherently less capable of learning than others. In reality, students differ in how they process information, understand concepts, retain knowledge, and demonstrate what they have learned.

When a teacher's expectations about how students should learn do not produce the expected results, they are labelled "slow". Once attached, the label can influence a teacher's expectations and affect the student's confidence, participation, motivation, and performance.

Teachers' role

Students may benefit from different ways of learning: visual representations, discussion, demonstrations, practical activities, reading, writing, repetition, or learning through experience. The important point is to recognise differences among learners and provide multiple pathways to understanding.

The teacher's role, therefore, is not merely to identify who is 'fast' or 'slow'. It is to identify barriers to learning, vary instructional approaches, provide appropriate support, and create opportunities for every student to succeed.

Instead of asking "Why is this student a slow learner?", educators might ask a more productive question: "What is preventing this student from learning effectively, and how can I change my approach to help the student learn?" This moves the focus from labelling the learner to improving the learning environment.

A student who struggles in a conventional classroom may possess talents that examinations fail to reveal.

Therefore, rather than labelling students as "slow learners", educators should recognise individual differences, identify strengths, remove barriers to learning, and provide every student with opportunities to discover and develop their potential.

Perhaps, then, the more important question is not "Who is a slow learner?" but "Are we being flexible enough as teachers to help every learner learn?"

The writer is an ELT resource person and education columnist. Email rayanal@yahoo.co.uk

SCHOLARSHIPS

Infocepts Innovate for Impact Scholarship
An initiative of Infocepts Foundation.
Eligibility: Open to students studying or domiciled in Nagpur, Pune, Chennai, or Bengaluru who are in UG programmes in Computer Engineering, IT, AI, ML, or Data Science, scored 60% in Classes 10 and 12, and have an annual family income not exceeding ₹600,000.
Rewards: Up to ₹50,000 / year for four years.
Application: Online
Deadline: October 30
www.b4s.in/tndy/INFO3

Aditya Birla Capital Scholarship
Instituted by the Aditya Birla Capital Foundation.
Eligibility: Open to meritorious girl students in Classes 9 to 12 or in Polytechnic Diploma, UG, or PG courses at recognised government institutions across India with minimum 60% in the most recent academic year and have an annual parental income not exceeding ₹600,000.
Rewards: Up to ₹60,000.
Application: Online
Deadline: October 30
www.b4s.in/tndy/ABCC18

Ujjivan Small Finance Bank Transgender Scholarship
An initiative of Ujjivan Small Finance Bank Limited, implemented through Buddy4Study.
Eligibility: Open to transgender students pursuing secondary, senior secondary, or UG/PG studies through a government or private institution across India, who have scored minimum 35% in Class 10 and 12 and have an annual income not exceeding ₹1,000,000 a year.
Rewards: Up to ₹40,000 (one time)
Application: Online
Deadline: October 30
www.b4s.in/tndy/USFB2

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

Reimagine Ideathon 2.0

The Central Depository Services (India) Limited (CDSL) has launched Reimagine Ideathon 2.0, an initiative that invites students to develop innovative solutions to strengthen financial awareness and cyber safety.

Eligibility: Students who have completed Class 12 and 18 years at time of registration and are currently enrolled in accredited Indian institutions. Team must have four students and one faculty mentor.
Deadline to register: October 30
For more details, visit https://ideathon.cdslindia.com/

What's your next move?

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help



OFF THE EDGE
Nandini Raman

I finished B. Tech CSE but could not get a job because of low salaries. I want to prepare for SSC-CGL, IBPS PO and so on. I am good at Advanced Maths, Reasoning and English, but not at Arithmetic and General Awareness. How should I prepare? Puneeth

Dear Puneeth,

SSC CGL relies heavily on speed in Arithmetic and Data Interpretation (DI) so focus on high-yield topics such as percentages, ratios and proportions, time and work, mixtures and alligation, and averages. Use your logical background to convert word problems into simple equations and solve them quickly.

For General Awareness, start with Static GK, Science and Current Affairs. Revise NCERT Science, Polity and History textbooks (Class 9 and 10) or Lucent's GK. Prioritise the Constitution — Articles, Amendments and Fundamental Rights — and Modern Indian History (1857–1947). For Current Affairs, cover national news, sports, awards and government schemes from the past six to eight months.

For IBPS PO, strengthen financial and banking awareness. Spend 30 minutes daily reading financial news, including RBI notifications, monetary policy, GDP projections and banking developments. Learn key terms such as Repo Rate, Reverse Repo, CRR, SLR, NPA and Inflation.

I finished B.Sc. Maths in 2018 and have been trying to clear the banking exams. Currently, I am working as a mentor at an online coaching institute. What are my job opportunities? How can I support my career growth, especially in the banking sector? Priyanka

Dear Priyanka,

Have you considered private banking or the NBFC or the FinTech sectors? Roles such as Credit/Risk Analyst involve evaluating borrower creditworthiness, analysing risk profiles and financial ratios. Private Bank Probationary Officer (PO)/Relationship Manager roles combine operations and client interaction, while Operations and Settlement Officers handle back-end operations, reconciliation and transaction audits. Banking/FinTech also offers Junior Data Analyst and Business Analyst roles, while ed-tech companies hire Subject Matter Experts (SMEs) and Content Developers to create tests, solutions and curricula for banking exams.

To strengthen your resume, build practical technical skills such as Advanced Excel, Financial Modelling, SQL, Power BI/Tableau and, optionally, Python/R for statistics. Short-term certifications such as NISM Series V-A (Mutual Fund Distributors) and Series XV (Research Analyst), or in credit risk assessment and financial statement analysis can add value. The Indian Institute of Banking and Finance (IIBF) offers courses such as the Diploma in Banking and Finance (DB&F), which can demonstrate domain knowledge to private banks.

I completed B.Tech. IT and cracked GATE. I now work as a contractual Assistant E-Governance Manager at MPSEDC, but my role is largely administrative. I want to return to technology and am considering GATE DA for a PSU role or an M. Tech. However, the difficult preparation phases make me overthink and consider alternatives like SSC CGL. How can I stay focused, build discipline, and avoid burnout?

Dear Yash,

Transitioning from administrative e-governance into a core technical field via GATE Data Science and Artificial Intelligence (DA) is a strategic move. Top institutions such as IISc Bangalore and IITs accept GATE DA scores for M.Tech programmes in Data Science, AI, Computational and Data Sciences and interdisciplinary AI branches. Traditional PSUs lean heavily on GATE CS, while government tech, defence research and specialised agencies have begun recruiting through GATE DA. If a PSU job is your sole priority, GATE CS offers broader vacancies; for AI/ML roles, DA is ideal.

Work on breaking your avoidance loop. When you hit a rough patch, do not pivot to another exam. Commit to one sub-concept or equation for 10 minutes. If a textbook causes fatigue, switch to a visual explanation, not another exam. Recall why you want to leave administrative e-governance: non-technical exams can lead to the same administrative roles. While working, use mornings for high-cognitive tasks and evenings for practice, revision and mocks. Decide the next day's topics and questions the night before. Keep Sunday free.

I have completed Bachelor's in Dialysis Technology and Library and Information Science and a one-year diploma in AI & ML. But I have low vision disability (50%) and getting a job is hard. What else can I do? Alagu

Dear Alagu,

Since your visual impairment is 50%, you meet the ≥40% threshold for Person with Benchmark Disability status under India's RPwD Act, 2016. This makes you eligible for reserved public sector quotas. Get the Unique Disability ID (UDID) card for exam relaxations and government job reservations. Register on disability-focused employment portals such as Atypical Advantage and Enable India. The tech industry hires professionals to test website and software accessibility for screen readers and magnification tools. Target roles include Accessibility Tester and QA Accessibility Analyst. Generative AI and Healthcare AI models require clean, tagged datasets. Target Medical Data Annotator and Health Data Curation Specialist roles.

Consider Assistant Librarian/Information Officer roles in government libraries and medical colleges. Banking exams such as IBPS/SBI also provide eligible candidates with a scribe, extra time, and magnified interfaces, subject to applicable eligibility and relevant guidelines.

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

Teaching beyond the textbook

Why India must rethink what education means

Anil Sarwal

Every year, as exams draw near, a familiar situation emerges: intensifying competition, soaring cut-off marks, tales of last year's toppers, and the desperate actions of those who fell short, whether by chance or through the negligence of authorities. This annual pattern highlights a core contradiction in our education system. While the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 set out a bold vision for holistic learning, six years later, a significant gap remains between the policy's promise and the classroom's reality. The time has come to move beyond marks; to stop mistaking scores for substance, and to relearn that education is meant to nurture thoughtful, ethical, and resilient citizens.

Uneven implementation

The NEP 2020, on paper, is a landmark shift: away from rote memorisation and high-stakes exams, and toward competency-based assessment, multidisciplinary learning, and the integration of vocational skills. It even acknowledges the importance of critical thinking, creativity, teamwork, and constitutional values.

Yet, its implementation is uneven. Teacher shortages, poor infrastructure, and institutional inertia have slowed progress. Rural schools often lack resources for project-based learning, while urban schools are gripped by a coaching culture that treats students as data points in national rankings.

The human cost is now impossible to ignore. Academic pressure remains a leading cause of anxiety, depression, and suicide among teenagers, as documented by the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights. More troubling, our system is producing graduates who can recite textbook answers but falter at problem-solving, emotional regulation, or civic responsibility, unready for a workforce that demands adaptability, empathy, and ethical judgement. Often, even basic reading and Maths skills are lacking.

These concerns prompt us to return to India's civilisational roots, where *vidya* (knowledge) was inseparable from *seva* (selfless service), humility, and character-building. Likewise, the principle of the inherent nobility of each person affirms that education must awaken virtues – not just facts – and encourage independent inquiry and constructive contribution.

Practical action

Realising this vision requires practical action. Teacher training must shift from lecturing to mentoring, emphasising formative assessment and inquiry-driven methods. Exam boards must accelerate the move from high-stakes finals to regular, low-stakes assessments that value application over memorisation. Schools must embed community service, ethical reflection, and real-world projects into the weekly schedule. Society – parents, media, and public conversation alike – must unlearn the reflex of equating a child's worth with a percentage. When families and the community recognise that a child's value goes beyond grades, it becomes possible to reduce competitive pressure.

India is at a crucial juncture. With growing awareness of the importance of quality education and guidance from NEP 2020, collective effort can make this vision a reality. Redefining success as the holistic development of individuals – intellectually capable, emotionally balanced, and socially responsible – encompasses our ancient traditions and democratic values. Future classrooms should aim to cultivate not only successful exam-takers but also compassionate, innovative citizens who contribute to national progress. The policy is in place; the key is the courage to implement it genuinely and provide adequate resources for its realisation.



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The writer is an Associate Professor of English (retired).

SAVE THE DATE

Admissions and scholarships

The University of Sheffield, the U.K., invites applications for its B.Sc. Computer Science (Artificial Intelligence).
Eligibility: Between 80 and 85% for students from Indian boards with Maths and Computer Science
Deadline: January 13
tinyurl.com/4twf4ps4

The Sheffield University Management School, the U.K., is offering a number of scholarships for students who hold an unconditional or conditional offer and will start the MBA programme in September 2027. Details at tinyurl.com/mrydunn2

The University of Strathclyde, Glasgow, the U.K., invites applications for its M.Sc. Sustainability and Environmental Studies course starting in January 2027. Scholarships are available.
Eligibility: A first- or second-class Honours degree in any discipline. Overall IELTS (Academic) score of 6.5 with no less than 5.5 in each band.
Deadline: December 11
tinyurl.com/5n8vy9e8

BITS Law School, Mumbai, invites applications for its five-year integrated B.A. LL.B. (Hons) and B.B.A. LL.B. (Hons).
Eligibility: Minimum 45% in class 12 and valid scores in BITS Law Entrance Test or CLAT, AILET, SLAT, MHCET Law, and LNAT.
tinyurl.com/8rffr32x

Swinburne University of Technology, Australia, invites applications for its Bachelor of Information and Communication Technology programme.
Eligibility: Completion of Class 12, overall ELTS score of 6.0, with no less than 6.0 in each band.
Deadline: January 15, 2027
tinyurl.com/4zxtuv3w

Fund your future

Tips for students to apply for scholarships for higher education



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Ketan Deshpande

Tuition anxiety is a silent academic killer. For many students pursuing high-stakes professional degrees such as BBA, BCA, MBA, or MCA, the most daunting hurdle isn't a final exam, but the looming invoice from the registrar's office.

But here is the reality most students miss: your degree's funding already exists. It is sitting in corporate social responsibility (CSR) budgets and private foundations, waiting for an applicant who knows where to look.

Here are five factors that will help:

Information gap: Many students are not aware of scholarship opportunities and how to apply for them. The problem is not a lack of talent, but lack of awareness.

Early start: Most students treat scholarship hunting like a last-ditch emergency effort reserved for their final year. Most scholarships offered by corporates open their applications to both UG and PG students from the first semester.

A student who begins applying in Year 1 and renews annually can build support across the degree's full duration.

High-value support: In the world of corporate philanthropy, not all awards are equal. While many offer modest assistance, a few heavy hitters provide life-changing sums that can cover the lion's share of professional degree costs. These include Reliance Foundation (offers ₹200,000 for UG and up to ₹600,000 for PG students and specifically names BBA, BCA, MBA and MCA); L&T Build India (full sponsorship for MBA students in Construction or Infrastructure); Bharti Airtel Foundation (full tuition coverage for UG professional courses); and HDFC Bank Parivartan (offers up to ₹75,000 for BBA, BCA, MBA, and MCA students). Programmes such as Colgate-Palmolive (Keep India Smiling) and Cummins India (Nurturing Brilliance) offer professional mentorship alongside tuition cheques.

Diversity and inclusion: Several corporates ring-fence funding for specific cohorts, where the applicant pool is far smaller and the odds correspondingly better.

For example, Adobe offers a Women in Technology Scholarship that includes money and a career-defining internship.

Flipkart also provides targeted support through its Girls Scholarship programme. Microsoft India and DXC Technology offer dedicated scholarships for students with disabilities.

To qualify for disability-specific funding, applicants must possess and upload a current UDID (Disability Certificate). Without this, even the most qualified applicant will be rejected automatically.

The management advantage: Banking and financial services are the natural first stops for BBA and MBA students. Institutions such as Kotak Mahindra (through the Kotak Kanya Scholarship for female MBA/UG students) and the SBI Asha Scholarship (up to ₹50,000) are explicitly aligned with Management curricula.

Students in these programmes should not waste their energy applying for programmes that are not meant for their degree.

Safe search

The professional scholarship hunt has its predators. So, to stay safe, remember these three points:

- No genuine scholarship ever charges an application fee.
- Never share an OTP or bank password with anyone claiming to process your award.
- Avoid agents who promise a guaranteed result for a cut of the money.
- Stick to verified channels such as Buddy4Study, Vidyasaarathi, and the National Scholarship Portal (NSP).

Most application portals are notoriously sensitive. To avoid technical rejection, ensure every document – Aadhaar, income certificate, and mark sheets – is scanned as a PDF or JPG and kept under 2 MB. Portals often crash or silently reject files larger than this without telling the student why.

Do not let a deadline decide your degree. Follow this systematic, five-step approach:

Shortlist: Pick five schemes you qualify for.

Verify: Confirm the income ceilings and dates of the year of application on the official foundation page.

Assemble: Build a digital folder with all the documents (kept under 2 MB!).

Apply early: Submit in the first half of the window to avoid the inevitable portal crashes.

Track: Record every application and renew annually.

The writer has a Ph.D. in Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) and is the founder, chairman and managing trustee of FUEL.

The power of ownership

Why teachers who might lose a bonus outperform those who might win one



THE KNOWLEDGE GAP
Ram Kumar Kakani

There is a Jataka tale about a merchant who promised one apprentice a bag of gold at the year's end and gave it to a second on the very first morning, saying only that it was now his to guard, and that a coin would be docked for every bargain he bungled. Both would end the year with the same purse. Yet it was the second, clutching gold that already felt his own, who rose earliest and watched every coin as though his life depended on it.

The old storytellers understood something deeper than money. We do not labour half so hard to win a distant prize as to protect what is already in our hands. Long before the economists, the fabulists knew that people rise to what they are entrusted with.

American experiment

In 2010, four economists tested that instinct in nine American schools. Teachers were offered a bonus of up to $8,000, tied to how much their students improved. One group would receive it at the year's end, as usual. The second was handed the money up front, on one condition: it was theirs, but they would return it if their students fell short. Same money, same target. The teacher afraid of losing it taught better than the one hoping to win it.

Traditional year-end bonuses had failed for years in America, producing gains close to zero. But the teachers who held the money as their own, and stood to lose it, lifted their students' maths scores by 0.20 to 0.40 standard deviations, the kind of leap you would otherwise get only by replacing an average teacher with an excellent one. Nothing had changed except the sense of ownership.

It would be easy to read this as a case for clawback contracts, but that misses the point. The finding is not about fear; it is about ownership, and how differently a person behaves once something stops being a possibility and becomes a responsibility. India has tested the gentler version and found it works: across 300 government schools in Andhra Pradesh, a bonus averaging three percent of pay raised achievement by 0.27 standard deviations in maths, with none of the feared side-effects. Teachers taught better not because they were threatened, but because the progress had been made, visibly, theirs.

In reality

For students, the same truth governs your own effort. You will study hardest not for a grade dangled in the distance, but for goals that already feel like yours: the streak you refuse to break, the project you have claimed, the standard you have decided is non-negotiable. Ownership is the engine. Learn to hand it to yourself, and no external incentive will be your master.

For faculty and leadership, the lesson is to build ownership rather than fear. The finest teachers already carry it, treating each student's potential as something they stand to lose if they teach carelessly. Vice-Chancellors, Deans and HoDs cultivate it by handing faculty real authority over what they teach and how they assess it, as custodians rather than employees. And the Boards of Studies and Examination Committees must remember that ownership only motivates when what is owned can be fairly measured: the integrity of the ruler must come before the reward for the result.

Read carelessly, the American experiment says, "threaten your teachers." Read wisely, it says what the Jataka merchant knew all along: the apprentice worked harder not because gold could be taken from him, but because he had been trusted with it. Fear was the crude mechanism; ownership was the true cause. India employs over one crore teachers, the largest force on earth, yet carries close to 10 lakh vacant posts; when one teacher does the work of two, what draws her fully into it is the whole game.

Our task this decade is not merely to fill those empty desks, but to make each teacher who fills them feel that the learning of every child is already hers to protect. Hand a teacher that trust, and she will guard it better than any contract could compel. That is the only incentive that never wears off. The purse was never the point; the trust always was.

Views expressed are personal

The writer is the Vice-Chancellor of RV University, Karnataka



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Before the assignment

Why every university needs an AI-evaluation layer before an AI curriculum

Swaminathan Ganesan

As Artificial Intelligence (AI) transforms the very structure of education, there is a concern about academic honesty. But the bigger question is: are universities addressing the wrong problem?

Overall framework

The focus has been on detecting the use of AI in assignments. But before pouring millions into AI curriculum, certificates, and specialised programmes, an institution needs to reconsider the way of measuring knowledge gained. This means an AI-assessment layer, which is not just software that grades assignments or detects AI-generated content but an institution-wide framework that combines redesigned assessment formats, clearly defined rubrics, continuous evidence of learning, responsible use of technology and educator oversight to establish what students genuinely understand and can apply.

Generative AI is changing not only the way students conduct their academic work but also the process of creation, consumption, and application of knowledge. Acknowledging this trend, the 2026 OECD report on responsible and systematic GenAI adoption in higher education notes that AI is reshaping not only teaching and learning, but also assessment, academic integrity, the skills students require, and the way institutions are governed. The key challenge, therefore, is not whether students will use AI, but whether current methods of evaluation can distinguish between output and genuine learning.



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A good layer of AI evaluation draws attention away from the final submission to the thought processes behind it. Universities will need a more varied assessment architecture that combines written responses with oral examinations, case analysis, simulations, demonstrations, reflective portfolios, project work and opportunities for students to explain their reasoning. Such formats provide evidence of reasoning, application, judgement and conceptual understanding rather than relying exclusively on the polish of a final submission.

Skills like adaptability, ethical knowledge, and problem-solving skills are increasingly being appreciated in the job market today but are not measurable through traditional means. Descriptive assessments will remain particularly important because they reveal how students organise ideas, apply concepts and construct arguments. The challenge is to evaluate these responses consistently, efficiently and transparently, especially across large cohorts.

The UNESCO-MeitY India AI Readiness Assessment Report (2026) states that national AI readiness is not only about having technology infrastructure in place but also includes developing human capacity, responsible governance, ethical frameworks, and institutional readiness. Hence, higher education institutions must ensure that graduates develop the judgement needed to employ AI responsibly, and not just the skills to work with AI tools.

Critical thinking has become the defining skill of human knowledge and competence. The creation of an AI-assessment layer involves more than just the adoption of different types of examinations. Continual assessment, and not depending on one high-stakes examination will become very significant. What we need is not the exclusion of AI from education but designing assessments where human competence becomes apparent.

Question of credibility

There can be no question about the role of AI literacy in contemporary higher education. Students require knowledge of prompt engineering, AI ethics, algorithmic bias, data ethics, and other aspects of the societal impact of AI. But curriculum reform is not enough to solve the problem of credibility. I

As AI increasingly becomes part of every discipline, profession, and classroom, the institutions that lead this transformation will not be those with the best AI curriculum, but those with assessment systems capable of measuring higher-order thinking, validating genuine learning, and generating meaningful academic insights.

Ultimately, universities do not exist to certify that students can use AI tools. They exist to develop graduates who can think critically, solve complex problems, exercise sound judgement, and apply knowledge responsibly. That future begins not with an AI curriculum, but with an assessment system designed for the age of AI.

The writer is the co-founder and CEO of Smartail

Beyond the balance sheet

As finance evolves, here are five new career paths that impact the industry and offer long-term growth prospects

Arindam Ghosh

Finance has always been central to business but, today, organisations expect finance professionals to interpret data, assess risk, support strategy, and help business leaders make informed decisions. This has expanded career opportunities for students pursuing Commerce, Accounting, Finance, Economics, Business Administration, and related disciplines. Here are five finance career paths that offer strong long-term growth and impact.

Management Accounting: This will suit students who want to combine finance with business strategy and decision-making. It focuses on budgeting, cost control, performance measurement, and strategic planning. Aspirants should build a strong foundation in accounting, costing, budgeting, and financial planning through a Commerce or Finance degree along with data analysis, and advanced Excel skills. Professional qualifications such as the Certified Management Accountant (CMA) strengthen analytical and strategic capabilities. Graduates can pursue roles in financial planning, cost management, budgeting, and business finance across industries.



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Financial Planning and Analysis: FP&A enables organisations to make informed decisions through budgeting, forecasting, financial modelling, scenario planning, and performance analysis. Students should develop expertise in finance, accounting, economics, statistics, or data analytics and build practical skills in financial modelling, Excel, business intelligence tools, and data interpretation. FP&A professionals must translate financial insights into business recommendations, communicate effectively and think strategically. Career opportunities span corporates, banks, consulting firms, start-ups, and e-commerce companies.

Internal Audit: This has evolved from a compliance function into a strategic discipline that strengthens governance, manages risk, and improves business performance. Students from Accounting, Finance, Commerce, Business Management, or Law can enter this field, while certifications such as the Certified Internal Auditor (CIA) provide specialised expertise. Aspirants should also understand cybersecurity, technology risk, data governance, and analytics. Career paths include internal audit, risk and controls, compliance, and assurance roles across corporates, financial institutions, consulting firms, and public sector organisations.

Forensic Accounting: This combines accounting, auditing, and investigative expertise to uncover financial irregularities, detect fraud, and support legal and regulatory proceedings. A strong foundation in accounting, auditing, taxation, financial reporting, and business law, with specialised courses in forensic accounting, fraud examination, digital forensics, and data analytics is required. The profession demands analytical thinking, attention to detail, professional scepticism, and the ability to interpret financial evidence within a legal and regulatory framework. Opportunities span fraud investigation, forensic audit, financial crime, regulatory compliance, and dispute advisory across consulting firms, banks, insurers, law firms, and government agencies.

Risk Advisory: This helps organisations identify, assess, and manage financial, operational, regulatory, cyber, supply chain, climate, and reputational risks. Students from Finance, Accounting, Economics, Business, Statistics, Data Analytics can strengthen their profile through courses in enterprise risk management, governance, compliance, cybersecurity, or financial risk. Strong problem-solving, research, regulatory knowledge, and stakeholder management skills are essential. Graduates can build careers in enterprise risk, governance, compliance, and advisory functions across consulting firms, banks, insurers, fintechs, and multinational organisations.

Alongside academic knowledge, internships, live projects, case studies, competitions, and industry interactions provide valuable real-world exposure. . As finance evolves, professionals who combine technical expertise with business insight will contribute to long-term organisational growth.

The writer is Country Head at Institute of Management Accountants, India